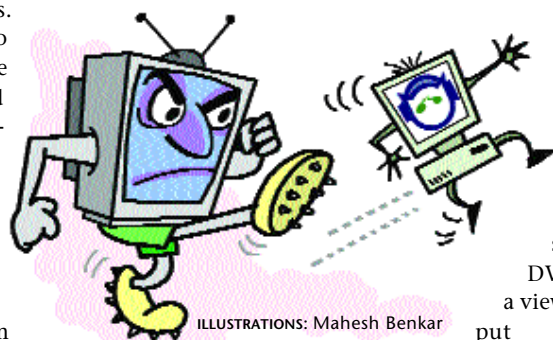


Regulated television?

In due time, TV signals will be broadcast digitally, giving you crystal clear reception of your favourite shows. But with digitisation's perks come its headaches. Content converted into digital files can be easily copied and exchanged over file-sharing services such as KaZaa and LimeWire. Movie studios and broadcast networks are taking measures to prevent their content from being distributed for free.

The Broadcast Protection Discussion Group (BPDG), an alliance of television broadcast networks, movie studios and electronics manufacturers in the US, has drafted a scheme that aims at preventing recordings of digital

television programs from reaching the Net and being freely swapped around in cyberspace.



Electronics manufacturers enter the picture because the scheme aims at controlling signals that are picked up by the TV set—they will have to include a demodulator which can distinguish between

analogue signals and digital ones. Digital signals will have a watermark, called a 'broadcast flag', embedded into their transmissions. Once the signal reaches the set, the demodulator encrypts it, allowing the content to be recorded onto other home entertainment components such as set-top boxes, DVD recorders, etc. But a viewer will not be able to put up the digital recordings on the Net.

Electronics manufacturers are not too happy, as this scheme will prevent recordable DVDs from being replayed on DVD players, which in turn won't spell any good for the development of digital recording.

redalert

Like father, like son

Klez.h is a true chip off the old block, Klez. It has trodden over its sibling Klez.i and is all set to overtake SirCam as the most destructive computer virus in recent times. Put together, the H and I variants of the Klez virus have superseded SirCam as the most active computer virus yet. The reason for this is that Klez.h uses different methods to disguise itself in its infection spree. And how do you fight Klez? Ensure that you update your anti-virus software regularly and have appropriate security patches installed for Microsoft Outlook.

Nothing to smile about

Simile.D, a new concept virus, might lead to rethinking of some of the fundamentals of anti-virus software. The program has code that not only works hard to hide the virus' presence, but also randomises the program's size so as to make it harder to identify. The latest variant of the virus can affect both Windows and Linux OSes.

With viruses such as Simile.D, anti-virus manufacturers must find multiple ways of recognising the code to effectively deal with the virus. This would however tax a computer's resources as it tries to find such stealthy programs. The virus by itself doesn't do much harm—on a Windows PC, it opens a dialog box on March 17 and September 17 with the author's name and the name of the virus. On computers running Linux, on March 17 and May 17, the virus posts a message with similar content to the console.

Windows XP update in the pipeline

Microsoft tested the first major update to Windows XP (Service Pack 1) in June 2002. Some of the important changes are the direct result of the antitrust case that the company is battling against. These changes will make it easy for consumers and PC manufacturers to override Microsoft's default products with third-party software from the firm's competitors such as AOL Time Warner and RealNetworks.

Under the Justice Department settlement, Microsoft must allow consumers or PC makers to hide user access to five pieces of so-called MS middleware: Internet Explorer, Outlook Express, Windows

Media Player, Windows Messenger and Microsoft's version of the Java Virtual Machine.

The service pack will also introduce support for new technologies such as Mira 'smart' display devices, Tablet PCs and the Freestyle digital media interface (a second XP interface for accessing the operating system's digital media functions via remote control).

Another part of the update is aimed at curbing the piracy of Windows XP. Although Microsoft had introduced Windows XP with Product Activation which uses a numeric key to lock the software to the hardware, code stolen from a

large customer led to large-scale illegal copying of XP. Those who are using illegal copies of XP will not be able to use this Service Pack or any other future updates. Microsoft expects to issue a final version of Windows XP Service Pack 1 sometime later this year.



snapshot

Roughly **600,000** films are illegally downloaded from the Net each day, an increase of 20 per cent from 2001

Source: Viant

■ HP to try out tablet PCs with the Compaq Evo ■ U Series X drive from Seagate aimed at game consoles ■ Comverse Technology to take over Odigo